



metroPLUS

THE HINDU

Ragas, punk, and Sly Stone's psychedelic soul to take over Chennai's music scene **P2**

DIRECTOR SASI OPENS UP ON NOORU SAAMI **P4**



We ask farmers across Kerala, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, and Telangana one question: Which mango would you choose above all others? They reveal the fruits they cherish most – and why preserving heirloom mangoes matters



Sankaran Namboothiri
Palakkad, Kerala

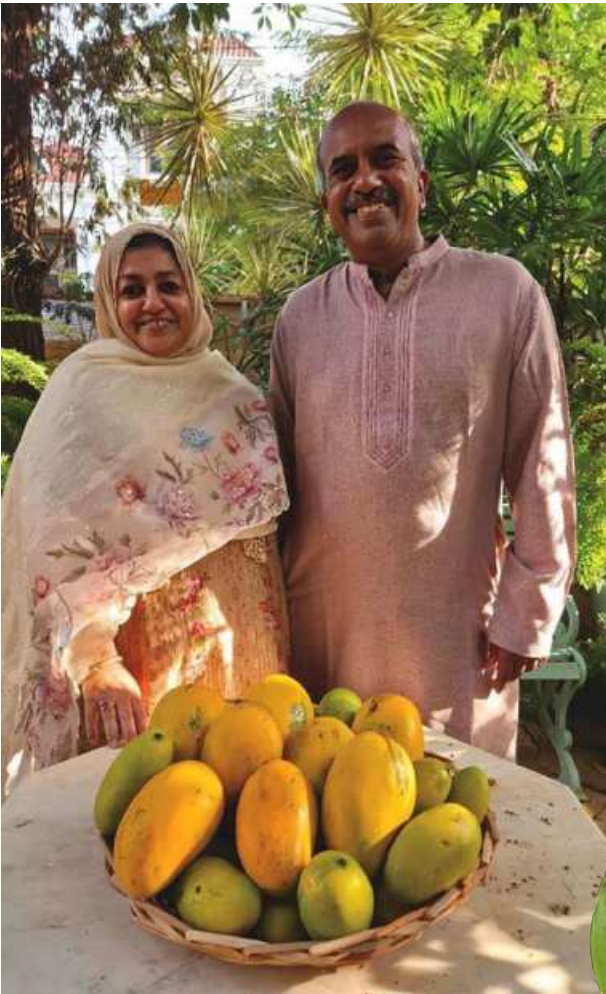
My favourite is a native mango variety, which as children, we called 'chakkarakodayan' since it was as sweet as *chakkara* (jaggery). I enjoyed sucking the juicy pulp from these small mangoes. It is no longer found in backyards of homes now. So I eat another local variety, Moorthy 1, from a four-decade tree which I named after our ancestral home, Moorthiyedathu Mana. Adapted to the local weather, this fruit grows in clusters. Each mango weighs around 100 grams, with a Brix level (sugar content) of 23, which is quite high for a ripe mango.

I have several indigenous varieties in my 4.5 acre farm, which is home to over 700 varieties of mangoes and several native trees. Farming has been a part of my life for as long as I can remember. Growing up in rural Sreekrishnapuram in Palakkad, I enjoyed plucking and eating the umpteen mango varieties from our backyard. Back then, I dreamed of growing them someday, a dream which was fulfilled once I became an organic farmer.

It has been heart-breaking to see several native mango varieties from Kerala getting lost over the years. Determined to try and conserve what is left, I started learning about mangoes, and

eventually could identify 443 local varieties, which I planted in my farm. I found that each district has its preferred variety: kottoorkonam in Thiruvananthapuram, karpooram in Kollam, and kuttiyattor in Kannur, etc. I have managed to collect most of these. I also have 17 out of the 22 Indian mangoes with GI tags, including kuttiyattoor from Kerala. Aroor olor from Kozhikode, which will soon get the GI tag is part farm too.

The diversity is exciting, from the flavour to the size, weight and shape of the leaves. I have a variety that bears fruits weighing five kilograms each, which I got from Tamil Nadu and have named sree, and another with mangoes weighing just 25 grams, which I call manjakadukka.



Asiya Khan
Chevella, Telangana

Growing up, memories of mangoes were centred around spending summer holidays under the tall trees in our backyard. We cultivated mangoes of the Deccan region such as benishan (Banganapalli), imam pasand, pedda rasalu and chinna rasalu. We would wait restlessly for the 'tapakna' (falling) period, when mangoes would be ready to be plucked. Oftentimes, we would start eating them even before they ripened!

The sight of mangoes soaking in big buckets of water was common through the summers of my childhood. Mangoes are soaked in

water to neutralise the 'heat-producing' effect and to get rid of the sticky sap that can cause irritation. My grandmother would check for ripe fruit from the lot and keep them covered in hay at home. It was a method she followed like clockwork.

My favourite mangoes will always be the imam pasand and Banganapalli. Pedda rasalu is best consumed under the tree, messy, without anyone bothering you. At our farm at Chevella in Telangana, we also grow heirloom varieties like panchadhara and swarnarekha. Panchadhara is a sweet juicy variety and swarnarekha is a mango with pinkish skin. We want to revive and save these varieties so that our native varieties not lost to genetically modified ones.



KS Jaganatha Rajaa
Rajapalayam, Tamil Nadu

I've tasted mangoes from almost every part of India, but the sweetest of them all is the sappattai that grows in the red soil of Tamil Nadu's Virudhunagar district. I grew up eating it every mango season since I was a child. The flesh is smooth and

juicy, and the juice trickles down your hand.

My second favourite is the panjavarnam, another variety that grows in Rajapalayam and its surrounding regions. I have revived through the grafting, several rare varieties that are native to Virudhunagar district where my farm is located. This includes mohandas, potalma, kovankachi. All of them have unique flavour profiles. One variety called theeyamavadi is crunchy like an apple and is best had unripe; another called karupatti kaai tastes like palm jaggery.

There is one other mango that I've recently taken a liking to. It is a variety that is yet to be named. Three years ago, I was called to identify a mango from a tree that is over 40 years old. The fruit from the tree is one-of-a-kind. It is small, sweet, and pulpy. The skin is tender and the flesh is devoid of fibre. The owners of the land wish to cultivate the variety to market it and requested my help in raising 500 saplings through grafting.

Sowing the seed

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Arun Sogathur
Bengaluru, Karnataka

While I grow many fruits, mangoes are my main crop. I have over 25 varieties on my farms: there are premium hybrids such as arka ambika, udaya, and suprabhath, as well as Tommy Atkins, which has a good colour, but less striking taste and aroma.

My favourite mangoes are imam pasand and arka suprabhath (a double-cross hybrid between Amrapali and arka annmol, with a firm, fiber-free pulp) because, while every mango's taste is unique, these two varieties remain firm even after ripening.

I also enjoy the appemidi mango, a GI-tagged pickle variety native to Karnataka, with a very good shelf life and a distinctive aroma and taste. The whole fruit is put in the pickle, without cutting, like vadu manga. It is a native variety, which has been around for hundreds of years. Now the native trees in the Shivamogga and Sirsi belt are being cut down because the trees grow very large, often reaching 200 feet, and the expertise required to harvest their fruit no longer exists. We grow this variety by maintaining the tree's height, making it easy to harvest.

However, the variety I grow the most is alphonso because that is what everyone seems to like!

Notes, fabricated

Carnatic music and Kanjeevaram silk come together for a jugalbandhi at Aavaranaa's Mid-Year Margazhi between June 19 and 21

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Vijayalakshmi Krishna says that Kanchipuram, the city of a thousand temples located only two hours from Chennai, has always been an artiste's playground.

Threads of silk from the houses of artisans come together to make fabric in hues that are sometimes yet to be named, making it the perfect base for experimentation. It is why as the founder of Aavaranaa, a 20-year-old clothing brand from Chennai, Vijayalakshmi is intent

that the first time she opens her store space for intimate events, she would like to weave in bits of Kanchipuram into the organisation's story.

Between June 19 and 21, Aavaranaa will be hosting the unusual Mid-Year Margazhi, an event that hopes to spotlight two Carnatic artistes in the city, while also hosting a talk. "Much of the performances in Chennai are clustered around December and January. We wanted to change that," Vijayalakshmi says.

The festival kicks off with Carnatic vocalist Brindha Manickavasakan performing on day

1, followed by a talk on Kanchipuram's stunning temples such as the Kailasanathar temple and the Varadaraja Perumal temple by historian Chitra Madhavan on June 20, and a Carnatic music concert by artiste Rithvik Raja on the last day.

"Aavaranaa began as a saree brand but what has stayed consistent from then to now is our belief in Indian textiles and the artisans who have been involved in the process. We work with a small set of weavers and artisans from the temple town. But we have our own set of designs and colours that we ask them to work with. Although I



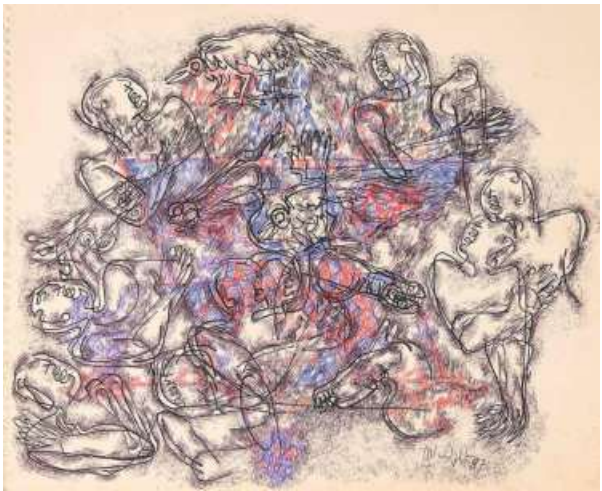
A step forward Singer Rithvik Raja. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

do not visit as often as I once did, we still are actively in touch.

Kanjeevaram weaves are excessively used in sarees but they make for great pieces in our ready-to-wear collection too. Because the fabric and silk has played such a significant role, our performers will be weaving the story of the town in their performances," she says.

Vijayalakshmi adds that she hopes that more events at their store would allow for talent, particularly upcoming artistes to perform here.

Mid-year Margazhi will be on from June 19 to 21 with Brindha Manickavasakan performing on June 19 at 4.30pm; Chitra Madhavan speaking on June 20 at 11am; and Rithvik Raja on June 21 at 11am. Entry is free but registration is mandatory. Contact them on Instagram @aavaranaa or WhatsApp 8939300020.



Silent sorrows
Through abstraction and layered textures, artist R Varadarajan turned personal experiences into evocative works of art. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Fragment of the self

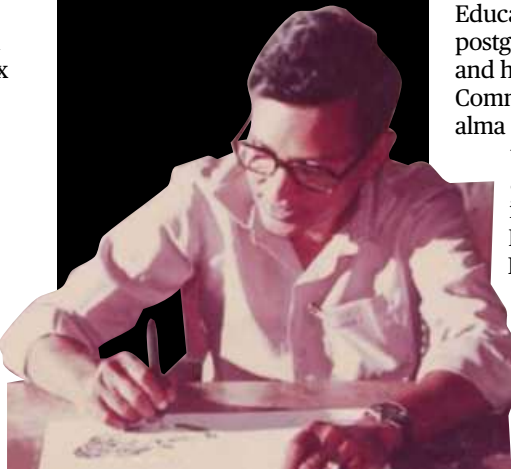
Priyamedha Dutta
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Can grief be turned into art? At Ashvita's, Vessels of Vulnerability, an exhibition of works by the late artist R Varadarajan, seems to ask exactly that. Filled with bold colours, flashes of red and layered abstract forms, the works do not reveal themselves immediately. But the longer you look at them, the more they expound on the idea of memory, loss, and emotional turmoil.

Built through abstraction and textured with paper stencils and old materials, his canvases transform deeply personal experiences into something personal, suggesting that human emotions are simply too complex to be captured through realistic images.

Born in 1935 in Tamil Nadu, Varadarajan studied at the Government College of Arts and Crafts in Chennai under KCS Paniker in 1959. He exhibited alongside contemporaries such as KCS Paniker, S Dhanapal, HV Ramgopal, K Sreenivasulu, Reddeppa Naidu, K Kunhiraman, and many more. His paintings, drawings, and prints feature an abstract style

Vessels of Vulnerability at Ashvita's explores grief, memory, and the human condition through R Varadarajan's abstract artworks



distinct from the popular figurative art and tantric-based abstraction of the peers of his time.

“What makes Varadarajan's voice distinct within the Madras Art Movement is the way he moved away from direct cultural symbolism and turned inward toward psychological intensity,” says curator Rithik Pramod. In his artworks, the human forms are visible but rarely in full. “Instead of painting realistic scenes, Varadarajan became more interested in expressing emotional states like fear, sorrow, anxiety, and inner conflict. Abstraction, for him, was not about style or decoration; it was a way of working through experience and emotion,” adds Rithik.

Apart from abstraction, the exhibition also features his experimentation with diverse mediums and styles. A culture scholarship from the Ministry of Education supported his postgraduate studies in Painting, and he later taught in the Commercial Art department at his alma mater until 1994. His works were exhibited across India and internationally, including the 1961 Paris Biennale and the 1964 International Graphic Art Exhibition in Poland.

Rithik explains how most of Varadarajan's artworks arrive through a three-stage process: absorption, where he submerges into the

emotional aspect of human existence, like grief and human fragility; distillation, where he lets these heavy feelings settle in his mind; and residue, where the canvas reveals abstract shapes and colours, where he can pour out his soul. Rithik says, “his style becomes strong enough to hold the real weight of human emotion.”

The mood of the paintings also shifts over time. The darker, more introspective tones gradually give way to softer shades of yellow, blue and green, reflecting a period in his life when the artist seemed more at peace and in tune with his emotions. “The gestures and layered surfaces carry a sense of vulnerability and emotional tension rather than fixed meanings or symbols,” says Rithik.

Having passed away in 2019, Varadarajan's artistic life was marked by many accolades. He was the recipient of several significant awards, including the Tamil Nadu Ovia Nunkalai Kuzhu State Award (1976), the National Award from the Lalit Kala Akademi, New Delhi and the Mahakoshal Kala Parishad Award, Raipur (1984). Varadarajan's legacy teaches us that vulnerability should not be hidden but rather celebrated through colours.

Vessels of Vulnerability is on at Ashvita's, Radha Krishnan Salai, Mylapore, till July 17, 11am to 7pm. Entry is free.

Chatting memories



Some tastes never leave us. For many old-time Chennaiites, the unmistakable taste of Milan's bhel puri is one such memory

Nikhil Raghavan

Nearly five decades ago, when chaat was still a novelty in the city, the late Jaswant B Shah, a Gujarati entrepreneur with remarkable foresight, introduced Chennai to the vibrant world of bhel puri, paani puri, samosas and other traditional snacks. What began modestly inside Figurette, a beauty parlour run by his wife Kanakam on the then Village Road in Nungambakkam, soon evolved into one of the city's most loved snack destinations.

As business flourished, Shah shifted Milan to the bustling Chintamani Supermarket in Anna Nagar, where he built a loyal following through the 1980s and early 1990s. Unfortunately, ill-health forced Shah to close the establishment in 1996.

But some stories are too good to remain in the past. In the early 2000s, Shah's son Arjun Arun Shah stepped away from his corporate career to pursue entrepreneurship. Sensing a growing demand for quality ready-to-fry snacks, he launched The Samosa Factory.

Having successfully established the brand, Arun turned his attention to reviving Milan – not merely as a business venture, but as a tribute to his father's legacy. A few trial runs and enthusiastic customer responses convinced him that the city still

remembered, and missed, the iconic flavours of Milan. Today, Milan Chaats has found a new home at Madras Food Walk on Arcot Road, Porur.

During a recent visit to The Samosa Factory's Milan Chaats outlet, Arun could be seen preparing orders behind the counter. One spoonful of the bhel puri instantly transported me back decades. The taste was unchanged – balanced, crisp, and layered with the familiar tang that once made Milan famous. Arun explains that the original recipes, chutneys, and ingredient ratios were meticulously documented by his father and continue to guide the kitchen even today.

Milan Chaats offer pani puri, aloo chaat, samosa channa, cutlet channa, dahi puri, and sev puri. Even the takeaway experience has been thoughtfully designed. Ingredients are packed separately so customers can mix them fresh at home, ensuring the crunch and flavour remain intact until the very last bite.

The story does not end with Arun. His son Arjun now manages The Samosa Factory unit in Anna Nagar, overseeing the production and distribution.

In an age where food trends change overnight, Milan Chaats is not merely reviving recipes, but reviving memories.



Milan Chaats is at Madras Food Walk, Arcot Road, Porur. Contact 9940110499 for details.

Snacking on legacy
(Top) The new location of Milan Chaats; (left) mini samosas. SRINATH M.



Run, talk, heal
Organised by The Mind and Company, this 3, 5, and 8 kilometer run aims to break the stigma surrounding mental health and encourage open conversations. Beginning at Napier Bridge at 4.30am on June 28, the run will proceed to Vivekananda House. For registration starting ₹299, fill the form on @themindcompany_mico on Instagram.



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What happens when Carnatic ragas share a city with punk basslines? Or when centuries-old temple architecture gets a futuristic digital mix? This June, Chennai's music scene is opening its doors, making sure there is something to discover every weekend. One could start with Digital & Analog, the city's edition of Fête de la Musique, presented by Alliance Française of Madras in collaboration with Omnivoid Labs and DeeJayphani.

On June 20, Espaces 24 at Alliance Française will be transformed into an immersive playground of sound, light and motion. Titled Cerebral Soundscapes in Paradoxical Realms of the Future-Past and presented by Omnivoid Labs, the experience combines live music with audio-reactive visuals and interactive installations inspired by both Tamil and Franco cultural confluences.

“We have used 3D-mapped temple gopurams, finials, columns and symbolic

Sound check, Chennai

sculptures of Tamil architecture, alongside Parisian landscapes and European monumental inspiration using generative AI art as well as visual tools like Unity, Blender and TouchDesigner; thus blending elements from both cultures into one immersive environment,” says Roy Dipankar, founder, Omnivoid Labs.

The line-up mirrors the spirit of crossover, bringing together artists such as Geography of the Moon (band by Virginia Bones and Andrea Rubbio), Chennai-based film music director Jhanu Chanthar's new indie project Nila, electronic acts like Hanging Wave and homegrown talent Diffrekt, as well as globetrotters

Genre benders (Left) From one of the previous editions by Omnivoid Labs; (below) artiste DJ Phani Kumar aka DeeJayphani. SHANTANU KRISHNAN AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Ninad Palandurkar and Krishnamurthy Ramesh will also be conducting workshops on French contribution to electronic music during the day at the library of Alliance Française of Madras on June 20.

“The programming brings together local and global artists working across classical, electronic, post-punk and experimental aesthetics,” says Roy.

If the first half of Digital Analog is about futuristic music, Grooves N Gain is a love letter to the past. Opening on June 27, at AF Madras, the 10-day showcase curated by DJ Phani Kumar aka DeeJayphani tells us to step away from algorithms into the tactile world of vinyl records, gramophones and cassette players.

“Primarily, it will be vinyl records, turntables and old gramophone records. People will get an idea of how music was heard in the 1950s, '60s

and '70s,” says Phani. The event will feature workshops where people can learn how turntables work and even try playing records themselves. “A lot of people have only seen records and have no idea how they work. We want them to come, touch them and understand the whole history behind them,” he says. There will be a ‘Bring Your Own Record’ session, where collectors can share music from their personal archives.

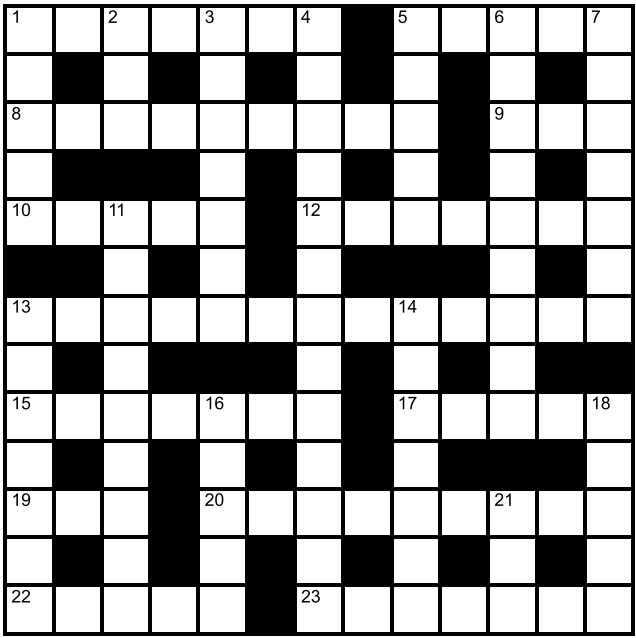
Beyond playlists and algorithms, Mother tongue Music's latest listening session is a trip back to the golden time of music. Returning for its third edition on June 28 at Vinyl & Brew, the series will take a deep dive into *Fresh* (1973), the landmark funk album by Sly and the Family Stone. Hosted by musician and composer Tenma, the evening is less a lecture and more an interactive exploration of the music, the politics and the cultural moment that shaped the record.

“The idea behind these sessions is to get people to discover music the way we used to – by hunting for interesting artists and albums, not just through algorithmic recommendations,” says Mukesh Amaran, founder and arts manager, Ma Medai.

From immersive digital worlds to the crackle of a spinning record, Chennai's music calendar this month invites audiences to listen differently.

Fête de la Musique will be on at Alliance Française of Madras from June 20 to July 5. Cerebral Soundscapes in Paradoxical Realms of the Future-Past is on June 20, at 5pm. Grooves N Gain is from June 27 to July 5, 6pm onwards. Entry is free. Mother tongue Music's listening session will be on at June 28 at Vinyl & Brew at 7pm and is priced at ₹500 on fanpit.in.

QUICK CROSSWORD #58 (Set by Doppelganger)



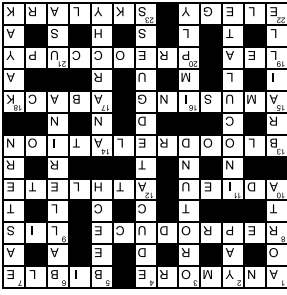
- Across**
- 1 No longer (7)
 - 5 Holy Book (5)
 - 8 Generate offspring (9)
 - 9 Heraldic design (3)
 - 10 So long (5)
 - 12 Sportsperson (7)
 - 13 Aunt, Brother etc (5,8)
 - 15 Comical (7)
 - 17 By surprise (5)
 - 19 Meadow (3)
 - 20 Enthal (9)
 - 22 Mournful poem (5)
 - 23 Bird (7)
- Down**
- 1 Blood vessel (5)
 - 2 Jabber (3)
 - 3 Pompous (7)
 - 4 Speculation based on knowledge (8,5)
 - 5 Deciduous tree (5)
 - 6 Dancer (9)
 - 7 Relating to the Orient (7)
 - 11 Imbue (9)

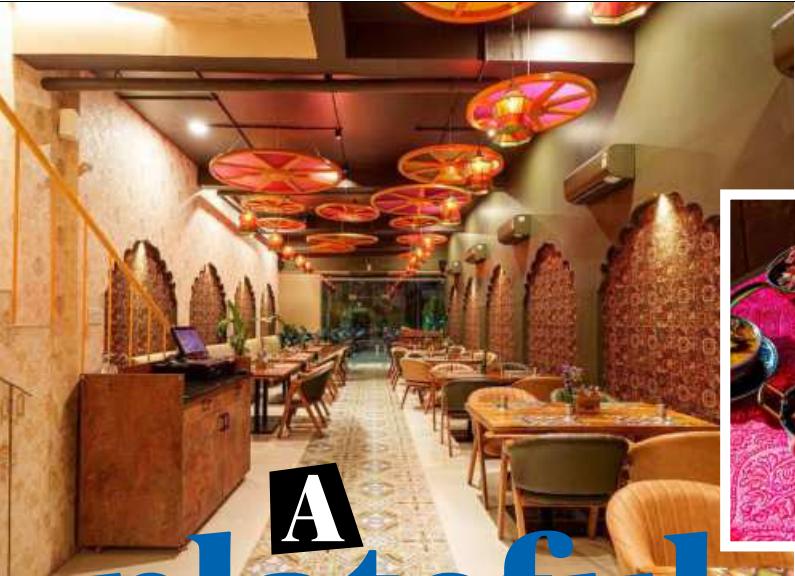
To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.



- 13 Writing system for the visually impaired (7)
- 14 Absence of government (7)
- 16 Signify (5)
- 18 Light boat (5)
- 21 Uncle Sam's land (3)

Solution No. 58





▲ **Stories made tastefully** (Left) Interiors of Parva; (below) menu spread; and (inset) a puri basket. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT.



A plateful of India

This pan-Indian restaurant will take you on a culinary journey across India

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Chef Arupam Baidya is a storyteller, and his menu, the tale.

At Parva, a new pan-Indian restaurant on OMR, he attempts to bring together dishes from 23 Indian states under one roof. The result is a menu that moves well beyond the familiar butter-chicken-and-biryani formula, inviting diners to explore lesser-known regional cuisines without leaving Chennai.

"Most Indian restaurants serve Mughlai and Punjabi cuisine predominantly. I have travelled around India quite a lot and have eaten from every State. The idea to open an Indian restaurant has always been on my mind, so I thought why can't we bring everything to one place," says chef Arupam. The restaurant caters to a growing IT crowd of people from across the country who often find themselves missing the flavours of home.

Given Chennai's heat, aam pora

shorbot, a charred raw mango drink, with cumin and black salt, makes for a refreshing start to the meal. We begin with Uttar Pradesh's palak patta chaat, which must be eaten immediately lest the crisp spinach leaves soak up the chutneys and yogurt, and turn soggy. Chhattisgarh's bafauri, steamed chana dal dumplings tossed in a flavourful tempering and served with a fresh green chutney, offers a delightful change of pace from the usual paneer tikka that dominates many starter menus.

Another standout was the fish kabiraji, a classic from Anglo-Bengali cuisine. The fish itself is delicately cooked, but it is the intricate lacy egg net wrapped around it that steals the show. The prawn ghee roast is rich and indulgent, layered with



spices that make you go back for more. While the tandoori section is mostly populated with chicken in different styles, the mutton barra kebab is aromatic and spiced in the right measure.

A meal at Parva is a lesson in food history and culture. Chef Arupam explains with interest, the history and journey of the bedmi poori. "It was called the travelling poori because it was preferred to be carried on long journeys due to its shelf life," he says pushing the poori basket towards us, which has an assortment of six different kinds of pooris from a kochuri, luchi, poori and more. The chena-r-dalna, a dumpling made with chena (ricotta) and simmered in the regular tomato based gravy; and the techa paneer gravy, which is heavy with green chilli spice and peanuts, go with the moti pulao. The flavours are familiar, yet distinct.

Being a South Indian, ending the meal with curd is essential and the ace up Parva's sleeve is the dahi jalebi, a central Indian dessert combination of a syrupy sweet jalebi, served with a slightly tangy bowl of curd.

From dal bhaati churma and litti choka to black til chicken, Parva crosses State borders casually across the menu. Though it is an indulgent meal in familiar flavours, hearing the stories and how these flavours come together is an experience.

Parva is at Shop No 10, Shop In A Park, East Coast Road, Sea Cliff Conclave, Akkarai, Panaiyur. A meal for two costs ₹1,200.

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Being human

Director Sasi speaks about his upcoming Vijay Antony-starrer *Nooru Saami* and why he hesitates to collaborate with big stars



Godly roles
Director Sasi; Swastika and Vijay Antony in a still from *Nooru Saami*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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You wouldn't find many directors as calm and composed as director Sasi before the release of a film. That *Nooru Saami* – starring Vijay Antony, Swastika and Ajay Dhishan – has come out the way he envisioned, brings him peace. "I am relieved and happy that I made the film I wanted to make," he says. This is Sasi's first release in seven years. "I made a film called *Nooru Kodi Vaanavil* with Harish Kalyan and Siddhi Idnani; however, the film remains unreleased due to some reasons and will come out in a couple of months."

He confesses he hasn't been the most consistent filmmaker around; in a career spanning over 28 years, Sasi has made just

eight films, *Nooru Saami* being his ninth. This is why he accepts that his brand of filmmaking hasn't always been in the limelight as much as one wishes. And what particularly sets him apart is the fact that he has made only one film with a big star – the Venkatesh-starrer *Seenu*. "I make films about simple human beings. I am not someone who likes to shoot larger than life. And maybe that is why I haven't done films with big stars."

Even Vijay Antony, one of the biggest Tamil stars the director has worked with, seems to have chosen *Nooru Saami* and their earlier collaboration, the blockbuster *Pichaikaran*, for their offbeat nature. "Only he would accept doing such stories. Many heroes looked at *Pichaikaran* as the story of a beggar; he understood that it was actually the story of a rich

What I admire about Vijay Antony is that he has tremendous storytelling sense and knows the pulse of the common audience

SASI
Writer-director

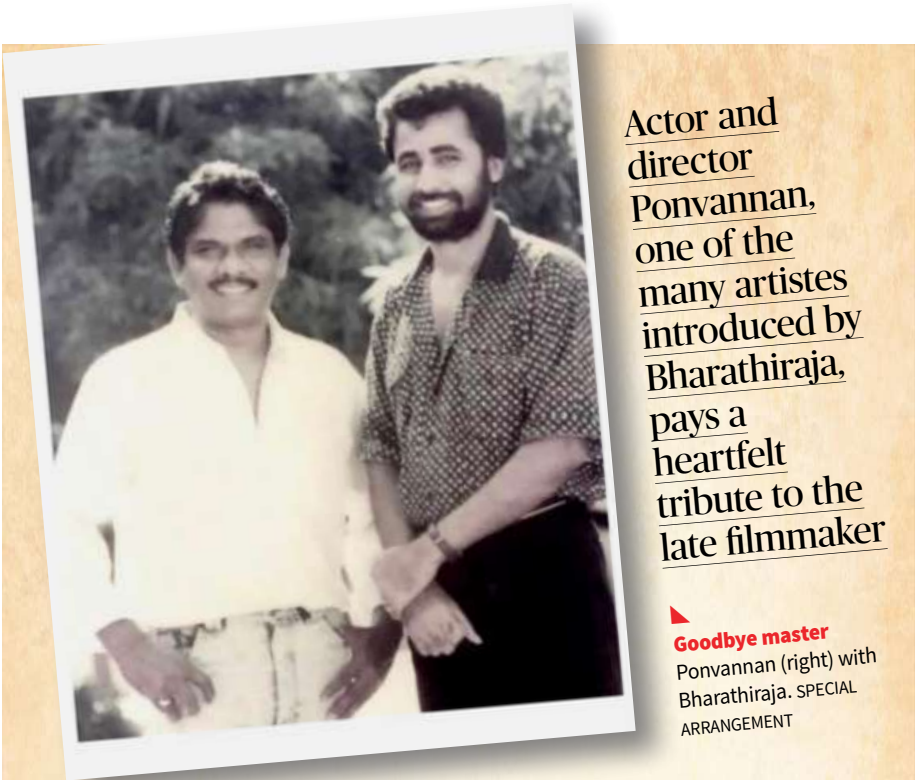
man." Sasi then drops a shocking reveal that *Nooru Saami* doesn't feature Antony as the protagonist.

Nooru Saami is essentially the story of a mother and son, and Sasi wanted Antony's nephew Ajay Dhishan to play the role of the son. "But after listening to the narration, he (Antony) said he wanted to do it himself. I was surprised. He said, 'No, let Ajay do the lead role, but I will do the character of Elumalai'." This further perplexed Sasi as Elumalai has very little screen time – "He doesn't even appear in the first half of the film," he says. "He then chose to produce it as well. What I admire about him is that he has tremendous storytelling sense and knows the pulse of the common audience."

Nooru Saami – the title of which is taken from the eponymous song from *Pichaikaran* – is a story about a middle-aged single woman who battles societal norms to build a life for herself. "If *Pichaikaran* asked sons to look at their mothers with reverence, this film tells them that she isn't God; just another human being. The story traverses what happens to a mother when her son learns to look at her as a human being." The core of this film, he adds, is inspired by a real-life story that Sasi came across while watching a reality show. "After the show, I contacted them and documented their life in 2022. Then, in 2025, I started working on a script."

To Sasi, there is no pleasure in the shooting of a film. "But there's tremendous pleasure in witnessing it come to life during post-production. I would think, 'Look how well the scene we imagined has come to life.' And I am happy to report that I have been getting a lot of such pleasurable instances in my last few films," he signs off.

Nooru Saami will release in theatres on June 19



Actor and director Ponvannan, one of the many artistes introduced by Bharathiraja, pays a heartfelt tribute to the late filmmaker

Goodbye master
Ponvannan (right) with Bharathiraja. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

To Sir, with love

Ponvannan

When news of Bharathiraja sir's passing reached me, I wasn't overcome by sadness; I was more relieved that he was finally free from pain. I felt somewhat at ease, it was as though I was the one who was freed from pain.

I didn't enter the cinema industry to become an actor or director. I was a painter, and I wanted to become a banner artist. When I couldn't sustain in the field, I began to tap into another skill: writing. It was my journey to become a writer that eventually brought me to Bharathiraja sir. While working on sets, I became friends with an art director named Devadas, who had been working in his films. It was Devadas who told Bharathiraja sir about this young boy who paints well and works sincerely. That's how I met him. He then saw the work I had done, and on the first meeting, asked me to work under him as an assistant director. My bond with Bharathiraja sir started then. And life gifted me the opportunity to share a personal bond with him over the years.

After inducting me as his assistant, he also promoted me to write dialogues for a few of his films. In fact, after I failed as a director, he gave me a new lease of life as an actor in *Pudhu Nellu Pudhu Naathu*. It was I who asked him for that opportunity, telling him I needed something to sustain myself financially. And to this day, it is acting that sustains my life. I won't say he gave me that opportunity because I was a talented actor; he had great affection for me, and was dejected that someone he thought would become a successful filmmaker failed. If I am able to make a living as an actor today, it is because Director understood my situation and helped me. For as long as I am alive, I will be grateful for that.

Bharathiraja was a wild plant, someone who grew roots by himself to take sustenance and sprout branches. That plant moulded itself, and it wouldn't let anyone else mould it. He was stubborn, and while he gained a lot due to this quality, he also lost a lot.

However, he kept tabs on his victories and losses and was always of the opinion

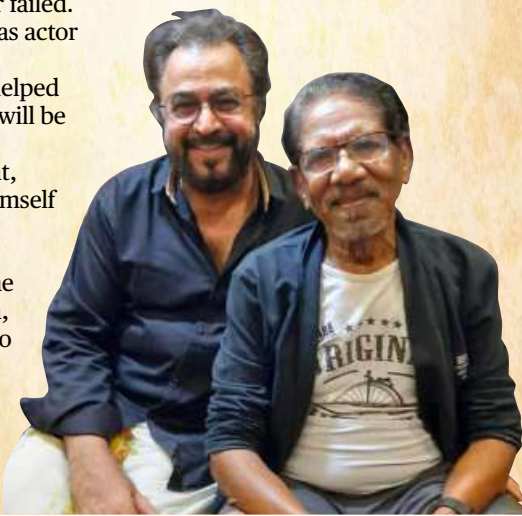
that he won more than he lost. He was stubborn even when it came to something like choosing a location. We would have come across a beautiful spot that was accessible, but he would pick a different location that was rough or raw. He would opt for the latter, even if it cost a lot to access the spot.

He would chop off a beautiful scene in the editing room if he felt it wasn't right. We would argue with him, but he would defend himself, stating it was he who shot it in the first place. He was someone who only followed his intuition. Because I understood this very early, it became easier to travel with him. That, in turn, made him like me more – I became someone who would offer what he had in mind, rather than bringing my own ideas to the mix.

His face always had a certain rugged expression whenever I met him. I have also seen him laugh a lot, behave playfully. But yesterday, when I saw his mortal remains, there were no expressions on his face. I had never seen him like that. It was like a clean slate. I imagined him calling me, 'Vaa da Shanmugam', and subconsciously, I had a whole conversation with him right there.

I told him, 'You have lived a full life, sir. Go well.' Ours was a bond that had love, anger, happiness, and respect. We come across many people in our lives. But not all of them would become as important as our parents or siblings. Bharathiraja sir was one such person. I will cherish memories of him for life.

As told to Bhuvanesh Chandar



Action mode
Samantha in *Maa Inti Bangaaram*; (inset) Nandini Reddy. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The good wife

Director Nandini Reddy on working with Samantha in *Maa Inti Bangaaram* and embracing action for the first time

Sangeetha Devi Dundoo
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Days before the release of her new Telugu film *Maa Inti Bangaaram* (Engal Thangam in Tamil), which Samantha both produces and stars in, director BV Nandini Reddy is a bundle of nerves and excitement. Since making her debut with the rom-com *Ala Modalaindi* in 2011, that familiar mix of anticipation and anxiety ahead of a release has never quite left her.

"It is far more challenging to get audiences into theatres today," she says. The challenge, she explains, lies in persuading viewers that a film is worth stepping out for. "We have to make ourselves heard amid so much noise. We kept asking ourselves why we wanted to tell this story and whether it had enough to truly engage an audience," says Nandini.

Maa Inti Bangaaram marks her third collaboration with Samantha. Their previous outing, the 2019 comedy-drama *Oh! Baby*, was a runaway success. Yet both women are acutely aware of how viewing habits have shifted in recent years. "Sam is a hands-on

producer," says Nandini. "She understands that a film's marketing begins the moment it is announced."

The story originated with Raj Nidimoru, the film's co-producer, who co-wrote the screenplay with Vasanth Maringanti. Samantha plays a woman married into a traditional Telugu joint family while concealing a gangster past.

Set in the 1980s, *Maa Inti Bangaaram* grounds its action in realism while incorporating touches of manga-inspired stylisation. The film marks Nandini's first foray into large-scale action. She describes it as a steep but rewarding learning experience, particularly while working with action choreographer Lee Whitaker. "It also helped that Raj was on set whenever we needed to troubleshoot," she says.

Speaking about the film's period setting, Nandini mentions how young brides and grooms have traditionally been under pressure to be the ideal husband,

wife, mother or father. "What happens to a person's individuality and sense of purpose when they are constantly trying to fit in? When Raj told me this, I knew the story had a relatable core. Setting it in a time before mobile phones adds another layer to the drama."

Reflecting on a 15-year career that spans six feature films, a short film in an anthology and two web series as creator, Nandini says, "The pace at which I work is my Achilles heel. Now that I am collaborating with more writers, I hope to put out more work." Her next web series, she reveals, ventures into darker territory.



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